

1995

In the month of August, Kolkata became the first city to have a cellular network—Modi Telstra's MobileNet. This is what you might have paid for your cellular services then:

- m Security Deposit: Rs 3,000
- m Rental: Rs 156
- m Standard Rate: Rs 8.40 per minute
- m Peak rate (this was not supposed to exceed 4 hours per day): Rs 16.80 per minute
- m Off-peak rate (on Sundays and bank holidays): Rs 4.20 per minute

Handsets manufactured by Nokia and Motorola were available for anywhere between Rs 18,000 and Rs 30,000.

BPL Mobile and Hutchison Max won Mumbai, Airtel and Essar Telephone won Delhi and RPG and SkyCell won Chennai.

GSM swiftly gained popularity in India; though this might have been because we didn't really have a choice. Nonetheless, mobile telephony gained momentum and it is estimated that the number of GSM subscribers has increased at the rate of 70,000 per month since July 1999.

2002/2003

The beginning of 2003 saw the introduction of CDMA in India, pioneered by Reliance Infocomm. The ridiculously low call rates and a host of other features saw these little phones selling like hot cakes. In fact, with the entry of new players like Tata Indicom, CDMA has become so popular in India that today 25 per cent of all cellular subscribers are on a CDMA network.

The Indian telecom sector is still one of the more strictly regulated sectors of the world. As these regulations relax, we can only expect better and cheaper services on our mobile phones.